

Overhead Absorption Efficiency and the Cross Section of Stock Returns

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Abstract

This paper studies the asset pricing implications of Overhead Absorption Efficiency (OAE), and its robustness in predicting returns in the cross-section of equities using the protocol proposed by [Novy-Marx and Velikov \(2023a\)](#). A value-weighted long/short trading strategy based on OAE achieves an annualized gross (net) Sharpe ratio of 0.40 (0.39), and monthly average abnormal gross (net) return relative to the [Fama and French \(2015\)](#) five-factor model plus a momentum factor of 54 (51) bps/month with a t-statistic of 4.62 (4.45), respectively. Its gross monthly alpha relative to these six factors plus the six most closely related strategies from the factor zoo (gross profits / total assets, Operating leverage, Total assets to market, Book to market using December ME, Cash Productivity, Market leverage) is 22 bps/month with a t-statistic of 2.41.

1 Introduction

Asset prices reflect investors' marginal rates of substitution between current and future consumption, fundamentally linking firm characteristics to expected returns through their correlation with consumption risk. While extensive research documents numerous firm-level signals that predict cross-sectional return variation, the economic mechanisms driving these predictive relationships often remain opaque, particularly regarding how operational efficiency metrics relate to systematic risk exposures. We identify a critical gap in understanding how firms' overhead cost management efficiency—specifically their ability to absorb fixed costs through operational scale—captures exposure to consumption-based risk factors that drive equilibrium asset prices.

Overhead Absorption Efficiency (OAE) measures firms' capacity to spread fixed costs across production volume, directly affecting their operating leverage and sensitivity to aggregate consumption shocks. Firms with low overhead absorption efficiency face higher fixed cost burdens relative to output, creating operational inflexibility that amplifies their exposure to consumption risk during economic downturns when marginal utility is high (Campbell and Cochrane, 1999). This operational rigidity increases covariance with the stochastic discount factor, as these firms experience sharper profit declines when consumption growth slows, precisely when investors' marginal utility rises most steeply (Bansal and Yaron, 2004). The consumption-based asset pricing framework predicts that assets whose payoffs covary negatively with consumption growth command higher risk premia, as they fail to provide hedging benefits during bad states of the world (Breedon, 1979). During economic contractions characterized by declining consumption growth, firms with poor overhead absorption efficiency experience disproportionate earnings deterioration due to their inability to adjust fixed cost structures, increasing their systematic risk exposure (Garcia-Feijoo and Jermann, 2005). This state-dependent relationship intensifies

during disaster risk scenarios, where consumption volatility spikes and investors demand substantial compensation for bearing undiversifiable consumption risk (Barro, 2006).

The OAE signal demonstrates strong predictive power for cross-sectional stock returns, with a value-weighted long/short trading strategy achieving an annualized gross Sharpe ratio of 0.40 and monthly average abnormal return of 54 basis points relative to the Fama-French six-factor model with a t-statistic of 4.62. The strategy’s performance remains robust across different portfolio construction methodologies, with alphas ranging from 44 to 65 basis points per month across standard factor models, all exhibiting t-statistics exceeding 3.38. Among large-cap stocks exceeding the 80th NYSE percentile, the OAE strategy delivers an average return of 37 basis points per month with a t-statistic of 2.52, demonstrating that the signal’s predictive power extends beyond small, illiquid securities. The long/short portfolio exhibits a significant negative loading of -0.58 on the HML factor with a t-statistic of -10.59, consistent with overhead-inefficient firms behaving like growth stocks with heightened sensitivity to systematic risk. After controlling for transaction costs using high-frequency bid-ask spreads, the strategy maintains a net Sharpe ratio of 0.39 and generates significant positive generalized alphas across all factor model specifications. When controlling for the six most closely related anomalies and the Fama-French six factors simultaneously, the OAE strategy retains an alpha of 22 basis points per month with a t-statistic of 2.41, confirming its incremental contribution to the cross-section of expected returns.

This paper extends the consumption-based asset pricing literature by establishing overhead absorption efficiency as a novel firm characteristic that captures systematic exposure to consumption risk, contributing to recent work linking operating leverage to expected returns (Novy-Marx, 2011). While Fama and French (2006) document the role of profitability in explaining cross-sectional return variation, we demonstrate

that the efficiency of fixed cost absorption specifically identifies firms with heightened sensitivity to aggregate consumption shocks, providing a direct operational link to the pricing kernel. Our findings complement [Zhang \(2005\)](#) by showing how production-based frictions manifest through overhead cost structures to generate predictable return patterns consistent with rational risk-based explanations rather than behavioral mispricing. The OAE signal’s robust performance after controlling for established factors and related anomalies, including gross profitability and operating leverage, indicates that overhead absorption efficiency captures a distinct dimension of systematic risk not fully explained by existing characteristics. Methodologically, we employ the comprehensive testing framework of [Novy-Marx and Velikov \(2023b\)](#) to demonstrate that OAE ranks in the top quintile of documented anomalies in terms of both gross and net Sharpe ratios, establishing its economic significance for practical portfolio construction. These results have broader implications for understanding how firms’ operational characteristics translate into equilibrium risk premia through their correlation with investors’ intertemporal marginal rate of substitution, reinforcing the fundamental connection between production efficiency and consumption-based asset pricing.

2 Data

We obtain financial statement data from COMPUSTAT, which provides comprehensive accounting information for publicly traded U.S. companies. Our sample includes all firms with available data in the COMPUSTAT North America database, spanning several decades of annual observations. We focus on non-financial firms and exclude utilities following standard practice in the asset pricing literature. Overhead Absorption Efficiency signal relies on two key accounting variables. Invested capital (ICAPT) represents the total capital invested in a firm’s operations, calculated

as the sum of long-term debt, preferred stock, minority interest, and common equity. This measure captures the cumulative resources deployed in the business that require returns to capital providers. Selling, general, and administrative expenses (XSGA) represent the period costs associated with corporate overhead, including management salaries, marketing expenses, administrative costs, and other operating expenses not directly tied to production. These expenses reflect the firm’s investment in organizational infrastructure and support functions. We construct the Overhead Absorption Efficiency signal by dividing invested capital (ICAPT) by selling, general, and administrative expenses (XSGA) for each firm-year observation. This ratio measures how efficiently a firm utilizes its overhead spending relative to its deployed capital base. Higher values indicate that a firm supports more invested capital per dollar of overhead expense, suggesting greater operational efficiency in leveraging administrative resources. We calculate the signal using fiscal year-end values from annual financial statements and require non-missing, positive values for both ICAPT and XSGA. To mitigate the influence of outliers, we winsorize the signal at the 1st and 99th percentiles within each year.

3 Signal diagnostics

Figure 1 plots descriptive statistics for the OAE signal. Panel A plots the time-series of the mean, median, and interquartile range for OAE. On average, the cross-sectional mean (median) OAE is -7.90 (-3.23) over the 1963 to 2024 sample, where the starting date is determined by the availability of the input OAE data. The signal’s interquartile range spans -9.15 to -1.30. Panel B of Figure 1 plots the time-series of the coverage of the OAE signal for the CRSP universe. On average, the OAE signal is available for 6.03% of CRSP names, which on average make up 6.61% of total market capitalization.

4 Does OAE predict returns?

Table 1 reports the performance of portfolios constructed using a value-weighted, quintile sort on OAE using NYSE breaks. The first two lines of Panel A report monthly average excess returns for each of the five portfolios and for the long/short portfolio that buys the high OAE portfolio and sells the low OAE portfolio. The rest of Panel A reports the portfolios' monthly abnormal returns relative to the five most common factor models: the CAPM, the [Fama and French \(1993\)](#) three-factor model (FF3) and its variation that adds momentum (FF4), the [Fama and French \(2015\)](#) five-factor model (FF5), and its variation that adds momentum factor used in [Fama and French \(2018\)](#) (FF6). The table shows that the long/short OAE strategy earns an average return of 0.41% per month with a t-statistic of 3.17. The annualized Sharpe ratio of the strategy is 0.40. The alphas range from 0.44% to 0.65% per month and have t-statistics exceeding 3.38 everywhere. The lowest alpha is with respect to the CAPM factor model.

Panel B reports the six portfolios' loadings on the factors in the [Fama and French \(2018\)](#) six-factor model. The long/short strategy's most significant loading is -0.58, with a t-statistic of -10.59 on the HML factor. Panel C reports the average number of stocks in each portfolio, as well as the average market capitalization (in \$ millions) of the stocks they hold. In an average month, the five portfolios have at least 499 stocks and an average market capitalization of at least \$1,213 million.

Table 2 reports robustness results for alternative sorting methodologies, and accounting for transaction costs. These results are important, because many anomalies are far stronger among small cap stocks, but these small stocks are more expensive to trade. Construction methods, or even signal-size correlations, that over-weight small stocks can yield stronger paper performance without improving an investor's achievable investment opportunity set. Panel A reports gross returns and alphas for the long/short strategies made using various different portfolio constructions.

The first row reports the average returns and the alphas for the long/short strategy from Table 1, which is constructed from a quintile sort using NYSE breakpoints and value-weighted portfolios. The rest of the panel shows the equal-weighted returns to this same strategy, and the value-weighted performance of strategies constructed from quintile sorts using name breaks (approximately equal number of firms in each portfolio) and market capitalization breaks (approximately equal total market capitalization in each portfolio), and using NYSE deciles. The average return is lowest for the quintile sort using cap breakpoints and value-weighted portfolios, and equals 33 bps/month with a t-statistics of 2.55. Out of the twenty-five alphas reported in Panel A, the t-statistics for twenty-four exceed two, and for twenty-three exceed three.

Panel B reports for these same strategies the average monthly net returns and the generalized net alphas of [Novy-Marx and Velikov \(2016\)](#). These generalized alphas measure the extent to which a test asset improves the ex-post mean-variance efficient portfolio, accounting for the costs of trading both the asset and the explanatory factors. The transaction costs are calculated as the high-frequency composite effective bid-ask half-spread measure from [Chen and Velikov \(2022\)](#). The net average returns reported in the first column range between 21-51bps/month. The lowest return, (21 bps/month), is achieved from the quintile sort using NYSE breakpoints and equal-weighted portfolios, and has an associated t-statistic of 1.54. Out of the twenty-five construction-methodology-factor-model pairs reported in Panel B, the OAE trading strategy improves the achievable mean-variance efficient frontier spanned by the factor models in twenty-five cases, and significantly expands the achievable frontier in twenty-four cases.

Table 3 provides direct tests for the role size plays in the OAE strategy performance. Panel A reports the average returns for the twenty-five portfolios constructed from a conditional double sort on size and OAE, as well as average returns and al-

phas for long/short trading OAE strategies within each size quintile. Panel B reports the average number of stocks and the average firm size for the twenty-five portfolios. Among the largest stocks (those with market capitalization greater than the 80th NYSE percentile), the OAE strategy achieves an average return of 37 bps/month with a t-statistic of 2.52. Among these large cap stocks, the alphas for the OAE strategy relative to the five most common factor models range from 42 to 64 bps/month with t-statistics between 2.82 and 4.76.

5 How does OAE perform relative to the zoo?

Figure 2 puts the performance of OAE in context, showing the long/short strategy performance relative to other strategies in the “factor zoo.” It shows Sharpe ratio histograms, both for gross and net returns (Panel A and B, respectively), for 212 documented anomalies in the zoo.¹ The vertical red line shows where the Sharpe ratio for the OAE strategy falls in the distribution. The OAE strategy’s gross (net) Sharpe ratio of 0.40 (0.39) is greater than 82% (95%) of anomaly Sharpe ratios, respectively.

Figure 3 plots the growth of a \$1 invested in these same 212 anomaly trading strategies (gray lines), and compares those with the growth of a \$1 invested in the OAE strategy (red line).² Ignoring trading costs, a \$1 invested in the OAE strategy would have yielded \$11.01 which ranks the OAE strategy in the top 1% across the 212 anomalies. Accounting for trading costs, a \$1 invested in the OAE strategy would have yielded \$9.88 which ranks the OAE strategy in the top 0% across the 212 anomalies.

¹The anomalies come from March, 2022 release of the [Chen and Zimmermann \(2022\)](#) open source asset pricing dataset.

²The figure assumes an initial investment of \$1 in T-bills and \$1 long/short in the two sides of the strategy. Returns are compounded each month, assuming, as in [Detzel et al. \(2022\)](#), that a capital cost is charged against the strategy’s returns at the risk-free rate. This excess return corresponds more closely to the strategy’s economic profitability.

Figure 4 plots percentile ranks for the 212 anomaly trading strategies in terms of gross and [Novy-Marx and Velikov \(2016\)](#) net generalized alphas with respect to the CAPM, and the Fama-French three-, four-, five-, and six-factor models from Table 1, and indicates the ranking of the OAE relative to those. Panel A shows that the OAE strategy gross alphas fall between the 76 and 95 percentiles across the five factor models. Panel B shows that, accounting for trading costs, a large fraction of anomalies have not improved the investment opportunity set of an investor with access to the factor models over the 196306 to 202406 sample. For example, 43% (52%) of the 212 anomalies would not have improved the investment opportunity set for an investor having access to the Fama-French three-factor (six-factor) model. The OAE strategy has a positive net generalized alpha for five out of the five factor models. In these cases OAE ranks between the 90 and 99 percentiles in terms of how much it could have expanded the achievable investment frontier.

6 Does OAE add relative to related anomalies?

With so many anomalies, it is possible that any proposed, new cross-sectional predictor is just capturing some combination of known predictors. It is consequently natural to investigate to what extent the proposed predictor adds additional predictive power beyond the most closely related anomalies. Closely related anomalies are more likely to be formed on the basis of signals with higher absolute correlations. Figure 5 plots a name histogram of the correlations of OAE with 210 filtered anomaly signals.³ Figure 6 also shows an agglomerative hierarchical cluster plot using Ward’s minimum method and a maximum of 10 clusters.

A closely related anomaly is also more likely to price OAE or at least to weaken

³When performing tests at the underlying signal level (e.g., the correlations plotted in Figure 5), we filter the 212 anomalies to avoid small sample issues. For each anomaly, we calculate the common stock observations in an average month for which both the anomaly and the test signal are available. In the filtered anomaly set, we drop anomalies with fewer than 100 common stock observations in an average month.

the power OAE has predicting the cross-section of returns. Figure 7 plots histograms of t-statistics for predictability tests of OAE conditioning on each of the 210 filtered anomaly signals one at a time. Panel A reports t-statistics on β_{OAE} from Fama-MacBeth regressions of the form $r_{i,t} = \alpha + \beta_{OAE}OAE_{i,t} + \beta_X X_{i,t} + \epsilon_{i,t}$, where X stands for one of the 210 filtered anomaly signals at a time. Panel B plots t-statistics on α from spanning tests of the form: $r_{OAE,t} = \alpha + \beta r_{X,t} + \epsilon_t$, where $r_{X,t}$ stands for the returns to one of the 210 filtered anomaly trading strategies at a time. The strategies employed in the spanning tests are constructed using quintile sorts, value-weighting, and NYSE breakpoints. Panel C plots t-statistics on the average returns to strategies constructed by conditional double sorts. In each month, we sort stocks into quintiles based one of the 210 filtered anomaly signals. Then, within each quintile, we sort stocks into quintiles based on OAE. Stocks are finally grouped into five OAE portfolios by combining stocks within each anomaly sorting portfolio. The panel plots the t-statistics on the average returns of these conditional double-sorted OAE trading strategies conditioned on each of the 210 filtered anomalies.

Table 4 reports Fama-MacBeth cross-sectional regressions of returns on OAE and the six anomalies most closely-related to it. The six most-closely related anomalies are picked as those with the highest combined rank where the ranks are based on the absolute value of the Spearman correlations in Panel B of Figure 5 and the R^2 from the spanning tests in Figure 7, Panel B. Controlling for each of these signals at a time, the t-statistics on the OAE signal in these Fama-MacBeth regressions exceed 0.21, with the minimum t-statistic occurring when controlling for gross profits / total assets. Controlling for all six closely related anomalies, the t-statistic on OAE is 0.88.

Similarly, Table 5 reports results from spanning tests that regress returns to the OAE strategy onto the returns of the six most closely-related anomalies and the six Fama-French factors. Controlling for the six most-closely related anomalies individually, the OAE strategy earns alphas that range from 26-54bps/month. The

minimum t-statistic on these alphas controlling for one anomaly at a time is 2.72, which is achieved when controlling for gross profits / total assets. Controlling for all six closely-related anomalies and the six Fama-French factors simultaneously, the OAE trading strategy achieves an alpha of 22bps/month with a t-statistic of 2.41.

7 Does OAE add relative to the whole zoo?

Finally, we can ask how much adding OAE to the entire factor zoo could improve investment performance. Figure 8 plots the growth of \$1 invested in trading strategies that combine multiple anomalies following [Chen and Velikov \(2022\)](#). The combinations use either the 154 anomalies from the zoo that satisfy our inclusion criteria (blue lines) or these 154 anomalies augmented with the OAE signal.⁴ We consider one different methods for combining signals.

Panel A shows results using “Average rank” as the combination method. This method sorts stocks on the basis of forecast excess returns, where these are calculated on the basis of their average cross-sectional percentile rank across return predictors, and the predictors are all signed so that higher ranks are associated with higher average returns. For this method, \$1 investment in the 154-anomaly combination strategy grows to \$2560.30, while \$1 investment in the combination strategy that includes OAE grows to \$2659.68.

8 Conclusion

This study provides robust evidence that Overhead Absorption Efficiency (OAE) represents a significant and economically meaningful predictor of cross-sectional stock returns. Our analysis demonstrates that OAE-based trading strategies generate sub-

⁴We filter the 207 [Chen and Zimmermann \(2022\)](#) anomalies and require for each anomaly the average month to have at least 40% of the cross-sectional observations available for market capitalization on CRSP in the period for which OAE is available.

stantial risk-adjusted returns, with an annualized Sharpe ratio of 0.40 and monthly abnormal returns of 54 basis points relative to the Fama-French five-factor model plus momentum. The signal’s resilience is particularly noteworthy, as it maintains statistical and economic significance even after controlling for established factors and closely related profitability and efficiency measures from the factor zoo, yielding a residual alpha of 22 basis points per month with robust statistical significance.

The practical implications of these findings are considerable for both academic researchers and investment practitioners. The minimal degradation from gross to net returns (Sharpe ratio declining only from 0.40 to 0.39) suggests that OAE-based strategies remain viable even after accounting for realistic transaction costs, making them potentially implementable in real-world portfolio construction. The signal’s ability to generate alpha beyond traditional factor models and related efficiency metrics indicates that OAE captures unique information about firm operational efficiency that is not fully reflected in current asset prices or existing factor models.

Despite these promising results, several limitations warrant consideration. First, while we employ the rigorous testing protocol of Novy-Marx and Velikov (2023), the persistence of this anomaly in out-of-sample periods and across different market regimes requires further investigation. Second, the economic mechanisms underlying the OAE effect deserve deeper theoretical exploration to understand whether this represents a risk-based explanation or a behavioral mispricing that may be arbitrated away as market participants become aware of it.

Future research should explore several promising avenues. Investigating the time-varying nature of the OAE premium and its relationship to macroeconomic conditions could provide insights into the underlying economic drivers. Additionally, examining the signal’s performance in international markets would test its robustness across different institutional and regulatory environments. Researchers might also investigate whether combining OAE with other operational efficiency metrics or employing

machine learning techniques could enhance predictive power. Finally, understanding the decay rate of the signal's effectiveness and optimal rebalancing frequencies would provide valuable guidance for practical implementation. As markets evolve and new data becomes available, continued scrutiny of OAE's predictive power will be essential to determine whether this represents a persistent market inefficiency or a temporary anomaly destined to be arbitrated away.

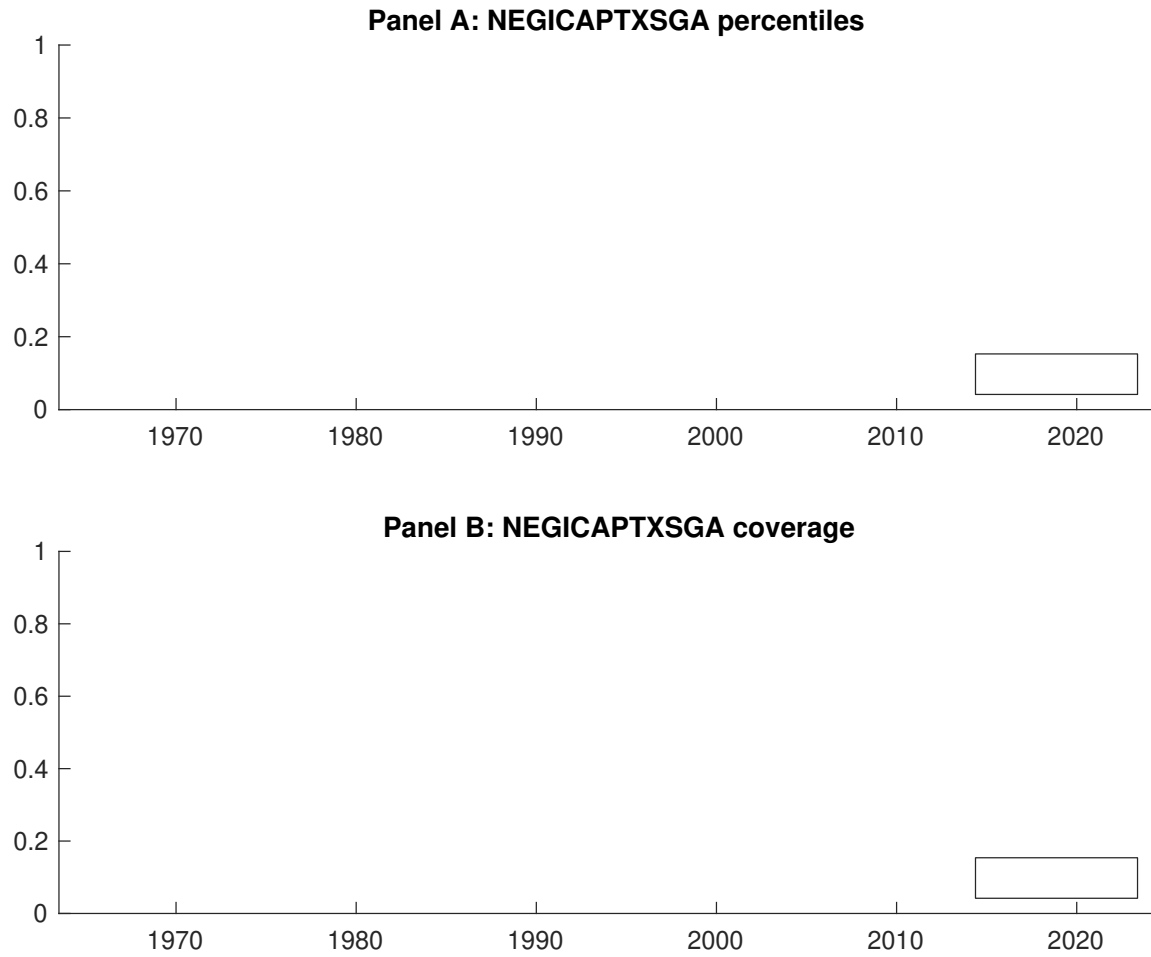


Figure 1: Times series of OAE percentiles and coverage.
This figure plots descriptive statistics for OAE. Panel A shows cross-sectional percentiles of OAE over the sample. Panel B plots the monthly coverage of OAE relative to the universe of CRSP stocks with available market capitalizations.

Table 1: Basic sort: VW, quintile, NYSE-breaks

This table reports average excess returns and alphas for portfolios sorted on OAE. At the end of each month, we sort stocks into five portfolios based on their signal using NYSE breakpoints. Panel A reports average value-weighted quintile portfolio (L,2,3,4,H) returns in excess of the risk-free rate, the long-short extreme quintile portfolio (H-L) return, and alphas with respect to the CAPM, Fama and French (1993) three-factor model, Fama and French (1993) three-factor model augmented with the Carhart (1997) momentum factor, Fama and French (2015) five-factor model, and the Fama and French (2015) five-factor model augmented with the Carhart (1997) momentum factor following Fama and French (2018). Panel B reports the factor loadings for the quintile portfolios and long-short extreme quintile portfolio in the Fama and French (2015) five-factor model. Panel C reports the average number of stocks and market capitalization of each portfolio. T-statistics are in brackets. The sample period is 196306 to 202406.

Panel A: Excess returns and alphas on OAE-sorted portfolios						
	(L)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(H)	(H-L)
r^e	0.35 [1.84]	0.54 [3.08]	0.71 [3.80]	0.63 [3.57]	0.75 [4.38]	0.41 [3.17]
α_{CAPM}	-0.26 [-3.09]	-0.05 [-0.90]	0.08 [1.32]	0.04 [0.63]	0.18 [2.89]	0.44 [3.38]
α_{FF3}	-0.38 [-5.11]	-0.15 [-3.05]	0.14 [2.54]	0.12 [2.20]	0.27 [4.56]	0.65 [5.64]
α_{FF4}	-0.37 [-4.90]	-0.11 [-2.31]	0.19 [3.41]	0.12 [2.12]	0.25 [4.14]	0.62 [5.29]
α_{FF5}	-0.37 [-4.90]	-0.16 [-3.26]	0.18 [3.06]	0.11 [1.91]	0.19 [3.24]	0.56 [4.84]
α_{FF6}	-0.37 [-4.74]	-0.13 [-2.62]	0.22 [3.76]	0.10 [1.84]	0.18 [3.01]	0.54 [4.62]
Panel B: Fama and French (2018) 6-factor model loadings for OAE-sorted portfolios						
β_{MKT}	1.08 [58.00]	1.03 [86.18]	1.02 [73.29]	0.98 [72.05]	0.96 [68.39]	-0.12 [-4.20]
β_{SMB}	-0.03 [-1.07]	0.00 [0.14]	0.06 [2.84]	0.03 [1.73]	0.04 [2.03]	0.07 [1.71]
β_{HML}	0.33 [9.14]	0.25 [10.82]	-0.20 [-7.33]	-0.19 [-7.33]	-0.25 [-9.19]	-0.58 [-10.59]
β_{RMW}	-0.05 [-1.37]	0.05 [1.97]	-0.05 [-1.81]	0.11 [4.04]	0.21 [7.72]	0.26 [4.75]
β_{CMA}	0.05 [0.99]	0.02 [0.45]	-0.04 [-1.07]	-0.11 [-2.84]	0.03 [0.76]	-0.02 [-0.27]
β_{UMD}	-0.01 [-0.51]	-0.04 [-3.68]	-0.06 [-4.26]	0.00 [0.21]	0.02 [1.14]	0.03 [0.91]
Panel C: Average number of firms (n) and market capitalization (me)						
n	499	585	603	659	873	
me (\$10 ⁶)	1213	1630	1918	2206	1609	

Table 2: Robustness to sorting methodology & trading costs

This table evaluates the robustness of the choices made in the OAE strategy construction methodology. In each panel, the first row shows results from a quintile, value-weighted sort using NYSE break points as employed in Table 1. Each of the subsequent rows deviates in one of the three choices at a time, and the choices are specified in the first three columns. For each strategy construction methodology, the table reports average excess returns and alphas with respect to the CAPM, Fama and French (1993) three-factor model, Fama and French (1993) three-factor model augmented with the Carhart (1997) momentum factor, Fama and French (2015) five-factor model, and the Fama and French (2015) five-factor model augmented with the Carhart (1997) momentum factor following Fama and French (2018). Panel A reports average returns and alphas with no adjustment for trading costs. Panel B reports net average returns and Novy-Marx and Velikov (2016) generalized alphas as prescribed by Detzel et al. (2022). T-statistics are in brackets. The sample period is 196306 to 202406.

Panel A: Gross Returns and Alphas								
Portfolios	Breaks	Weights	r^e	α_{CAPM}	α_{FF3}	α_{FF4}	α_{FF5}	α_{FF6}
Quintile	NYSE	VW	0.41 [3.17]	0.44 [3.38]	0.65 [5.64]	0.62 [5.29]	0.56 [4.84]	0.54 [4.62]
Quintile	NYSE	EW	0.34 [2.48]	0.26 [1.91]	0.41 [3.49]	0.49 [4.16]	0.57 [4.96]	0.64 [5.46]
Quintile	Name	VW	0.42 [3.16]	0.43 [3.27]	0.64 [5.49]	0.59 [4.99]	0.56 [4.74]	0.53 [4.39]
Quintile	Cap	VW	0.33 [2.55]	0.36 [2.77]	0.57 [4.92]	0.52 [4.44]	0.47 [4.04]	0.44 [3.71]
Decile	NYSE	VW	0.53 [3.17]	0.55 [3.24]	0.76 [4.88]	0.76 [4.76]	0.73 [4.54]	0.72 [4.46]
Panel B: Net Returns and Novy-Marx and Velikov (2016) generalized alphas								
Portfolios	Breaks	Weights	r_{net}^e	α_{CAPM}^*	α_{FF3}^*	α_{FF4}^*	α_{FF5}^*	α_{FF6}^*
Quintile	NYSE	VW	0.39 [3.06]	0.42 [3.21]	0.60 [5.25]	0.59 [5.10]	0.52 [4.54]	0.51 [4.45]
Quintile	NYSE	EW	0.21 [1.54]	0.13 [0.96]	0.26 [2.17]	0.31 [2.61]	0.37 [3.19]	0.41 [3.54]
Quintile	Name	VW	0.40 [3.05]	0.41 [3.05]	0.59 [5.09]	0.57 [4.86]	0.52 [4.40]	0.50 [4.24]
Quintile	Cap	VW	0.32 [2.44]	0.35 [2.66]	0.53 [4.60]	0.51 [4.37]	0.44 [3.80]	0.42 [3.65]
Decile	NYSE	VW	0.51 [3.05]	0.50 [2.98]	0.70 [4.45]	0.70 [4.43]	0.65 [4.09]	0.65 [4.09]

Table 3: Conditional sort on size and OAE

This table presents results for conditional double sorts on size and OAE. In each month, stocks are first sorted into quintiles based on size using NYSE breakpoints. Then, within each size quintile, stocks are further sorted based on OAE. Finally, they are grouped into twenty-five portfolios based on the intersection of the two sorts. Panel A presents the average returns to the 25 portfolios, as well as strategies that go long stocks with high OAE and short stocks with low OAE. Panel B documents the average number of firms and the average firm size for each portfolio. The sample period is 196306 to 202406.

Panel A: portfolio average returns and time-series regression results												
Size quintiles	OAE Quintiles					OAE Strategies						
	(L)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(H)	r^e	α_{CAPM}	α_{FF3}	α_{FF4}	α_{FF5}	α_{FF6}	
	(1)	0.51 [2.37]	0.71 [3.08]	0.83 [3.27]	0.88 [3.36]	0.76 [2.57]	0.24 [1.34]	0.08 [0.44]	0.24 [1.54]	0.27 [1.65]	0.49 [3.20]	0.50 [3.19]
	(2)	0.64 [2.78]	0.76 [3.41]	0.74 [3.18]	0.79 [3.28]	0.88 [3.56]	0.24 [1.72]	0.18 [1.27]	0.35 [2.81]	0.38 [3.01]	0.42 [3.33]	0.44 [3.48]
	(3)	0.68 [2.99]	0.69 [3.20]	0.73 [3.36]	0.84 [3.72]	0.83 [3.72]	0.16 [1.16]	0.14 [1.05]	0.31 [2.44]	0.36 [2.78]	0.34 [2.66]	0.38 [2.92]
	(4)	0.52 [2.39]	0.59 [2.86]	0.73 [3.49]	0.77 [3.68]	0.91 [4.42]	0.39 [2.81]	0.41 [2.96]	0.58 [4.52]	0.60 [4.55]	0.61 [4.58]	0.62 [4.61]
	(5)	0.33 [1.76]	0.53 [3.05]	0.69 [3.69]	0.59 [3.47]	0.71 [4.20]	0.37 [2.52]	0.42 [2.82]	0.64 [4.76]	0.62 [4.46]	0.55 [4.03]	0.53 [3.83]
Panel B: Portfolio average number of firms and market capitalization												
Size quintiles	OAE Quintiles					OAE Quintiles						
	Average n					Average market capitalization (\$10 ⁶)						
	(L)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(H)	(L)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(H)		
	(1)	375	378	377	375	362	35	34	33	29	22	
	(2)	100	101	101	101	100	52	52	52	51	52	
	(3)	69	69	69	69	69	86	87	87	87	87	
	(4)	53	54	54	54	54	174	174	176	179	179	
(5)	47	47	48	47	48	1009	1326	1715	1477	1319		

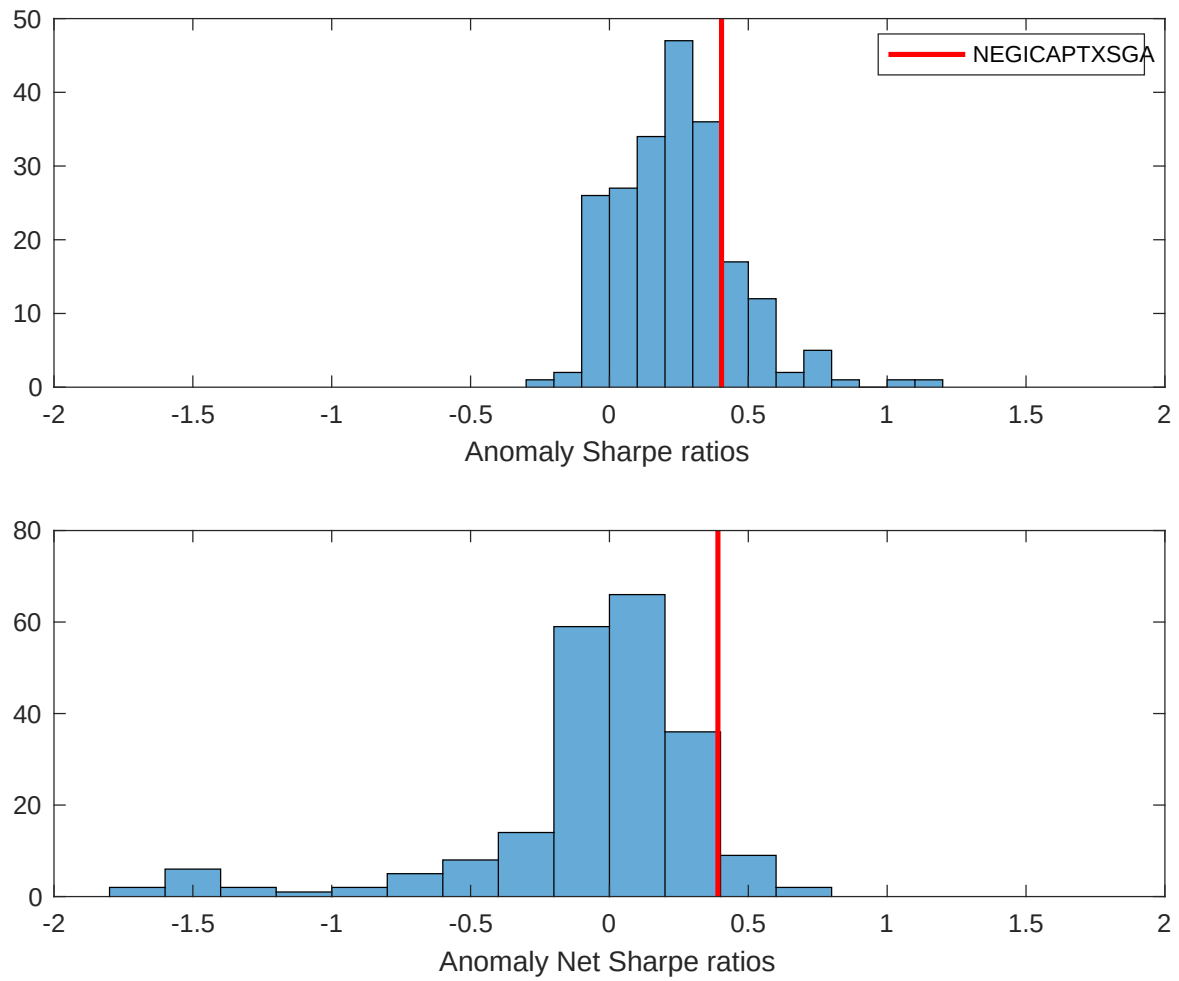


Figure 2: Distribution of Sharpe ratios.

This figure plots a histogram of Sharpe ratios for 212 anomalies, and compares the Sharpe ratio of the OAE with them (red vertical line). Panel A plots results for gross Sharpe ratios. Panel B plots results for net Sharpe ratios.

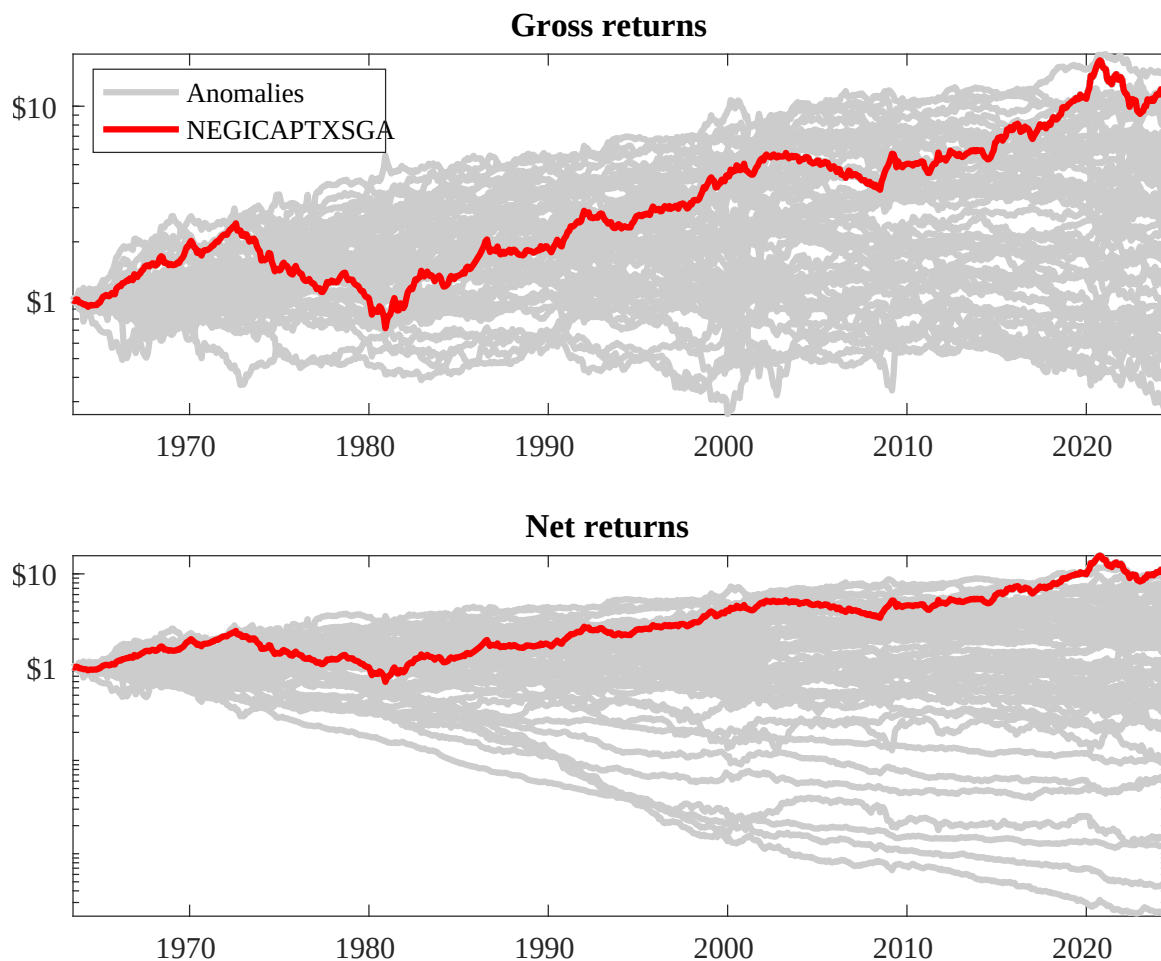
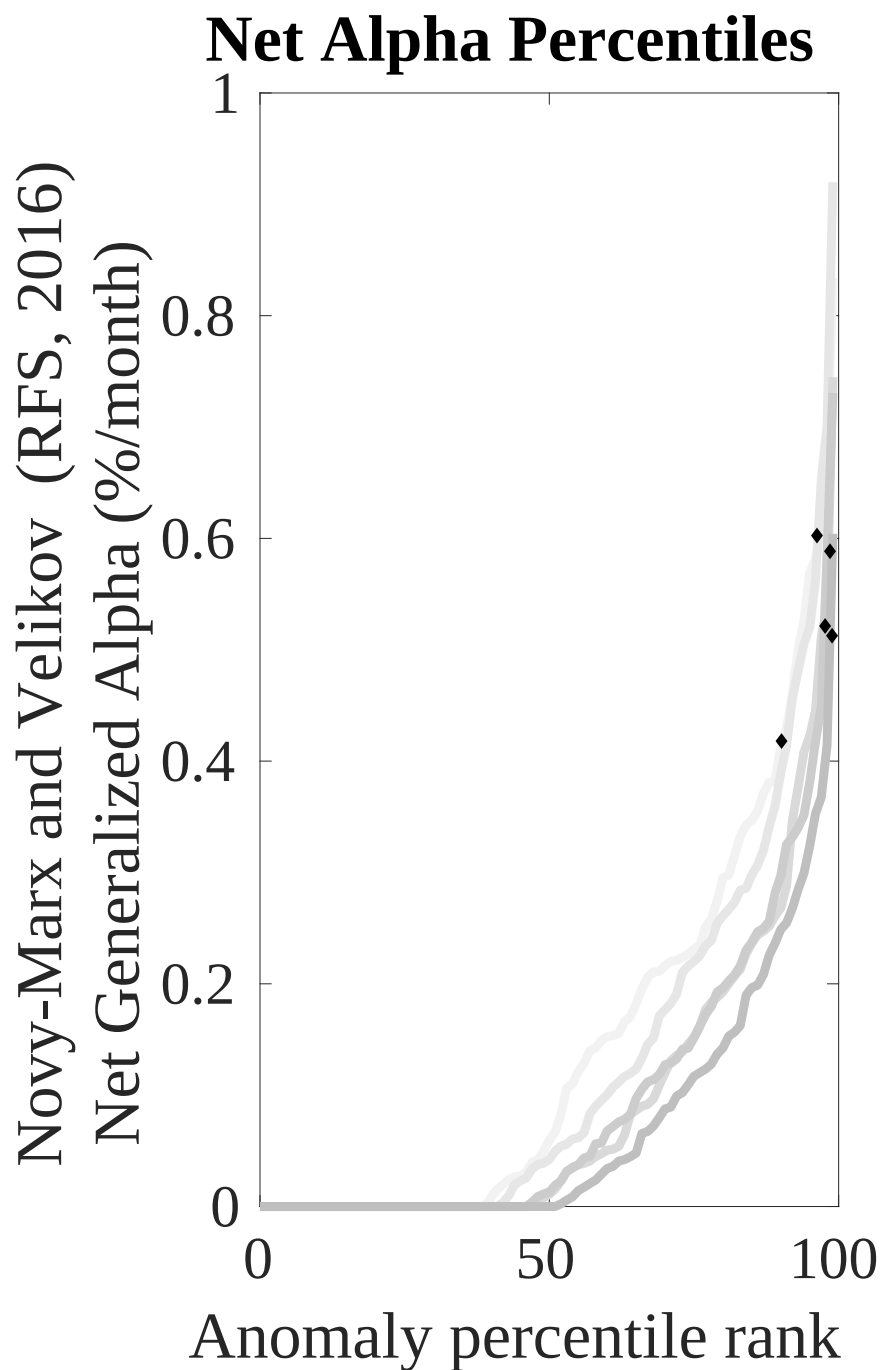
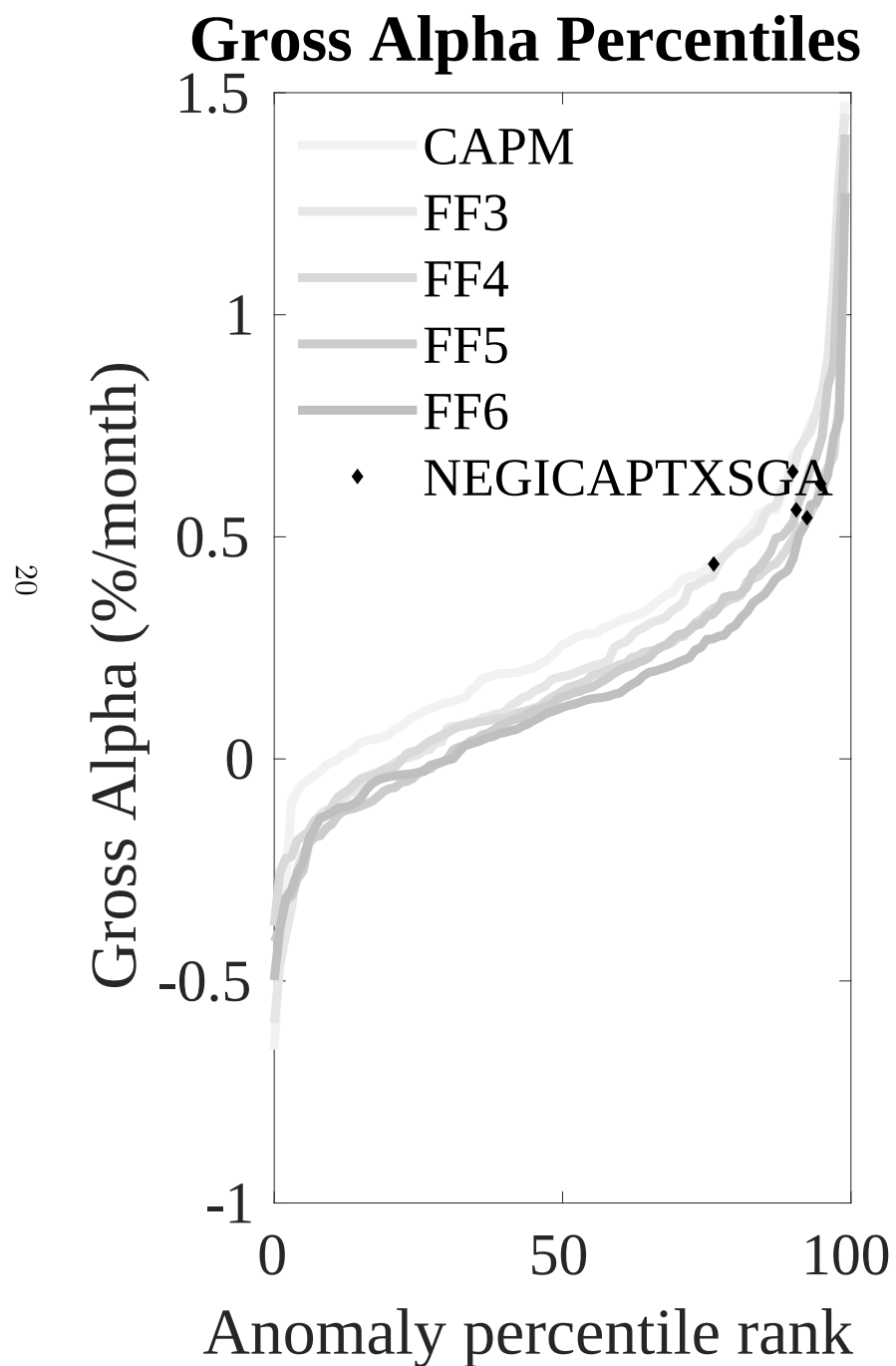


Figure 3: Dollar invested.

This figure plots the growth of a \$1 invested in 212 anomaly trading strategies (gray lines), and compares those with the OAE trading strategy (red line). The strategies are constructed using value-weighted quintile sorts using NYSE breakpoints. Panel A plots results for gross strategy returns. Panel B plots results for net strategy returns.



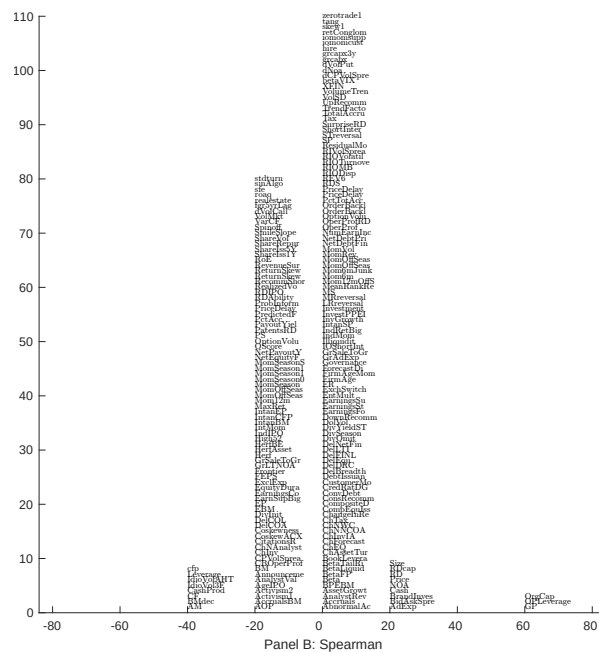
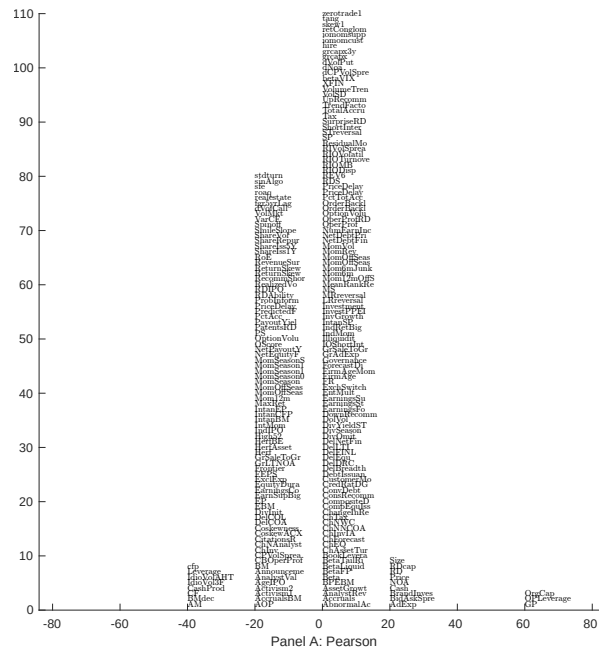


Figure 5: Distribution of correlations.

This figure plots a name histogram of correlations of 210 filtered anomaly signals with OAE. The correlations are pooled. Panel A plots Pearson correlations, while Panel B plots Spearman rank correlations.

This figure plots an agglomerative hierarchical cluster plot using Ward's minimum method and a maximum of 10 clusters.

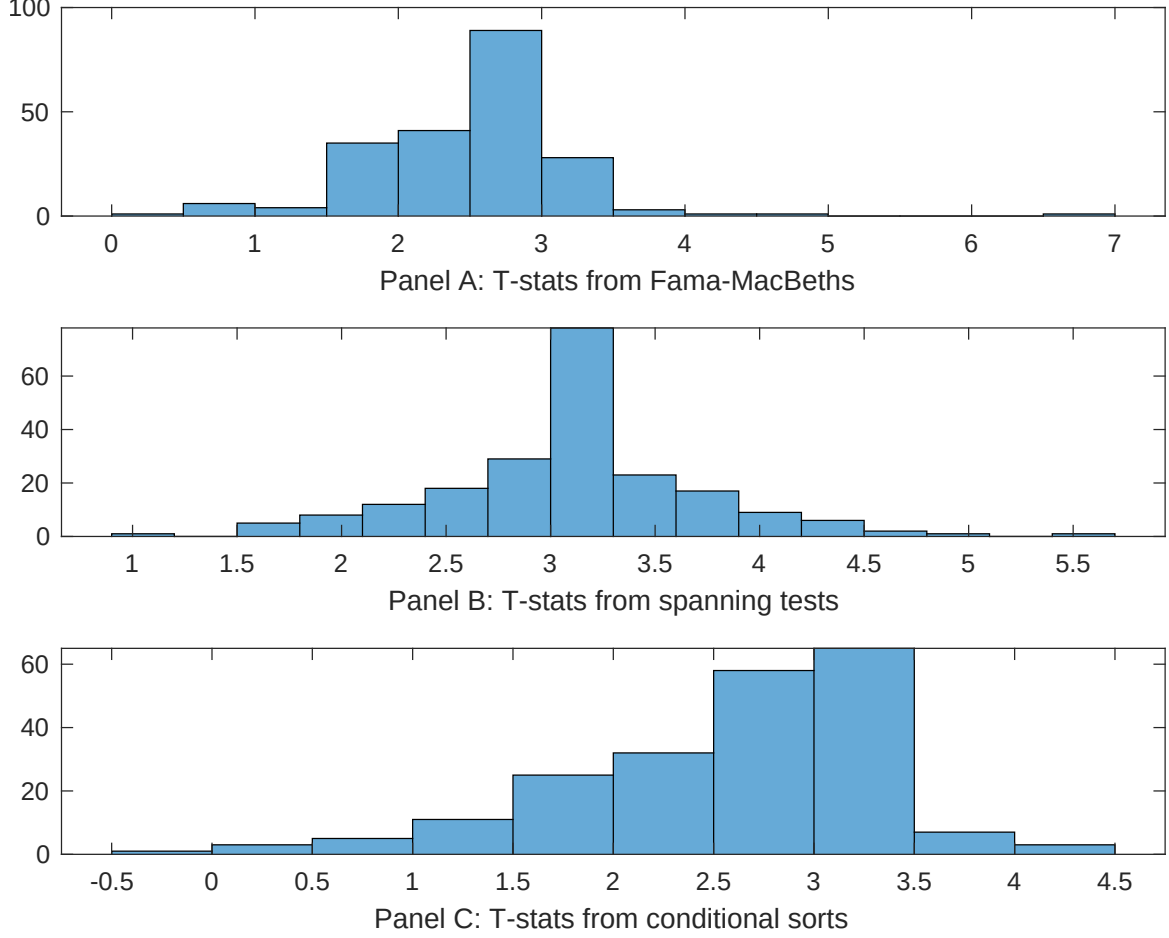


Figure 7: Distribution of t-stats on conditioning strategies

This figure plots histograms of t-statistics for predictability tests of OAE conditioning on each of the 210 filtered anomaly signals one at a time. Panel A reports t-statistics on β_{OAE} from Fama-MacBeth regressions of the form $r_{i,t} = \alpha + \beta_{OAE}OAE_{i,t} + \beta_X X_{i,t} + \epsilon_{i,t}$, where X stands for one of the 210 filtered anomaly signals at a time. Panel B plots t-statistics on α from spanning tests of the form: $r_{OAE,t} = \alpha + \beta r_{X,t} + \epsilon_t$, where $r_{X,t}$ stands for the returns to one of the 210 filtered anomaly trading strategies at a time. The strategies employed in the spanning tests are constructed using quintile sorts, value-weighting, and NYSE breakpoints. Panel C plots t-statistics on the average returns to strategies constructed by conditional double sorts. In each month, we sort stocks into quintiles based on one of the 210 filtered anomaly signals at a time. Then, within each quintile, we sort stocks into quintiles based on OAE. Stocks are finally grouped into five OAE portfolios by combining stocks within each anomaly sorting portfolio. The panel plots the t-statistics on the average returns of these conditional double-sorted OAE trading strategies conditioned on each of the 210 filtered anomalies.

Table 4: Fama-MacBeths controlling for most closely related anomalies

This table presents Fama-MacBeth results of returns on OAE. and the six most closely related anomalies. The regressions take the following form: $r_{i,t} = \alpha + \beta_{OAE}OAE_{i,t} + \sum_{k=1}^s \beta_{X_k} X_{i,t}^k + \epsilon_{i,t}$. The six most closely related anomalies, X , are gross profits / total assets, Operating leverage, Total assets to market, Book to market using December ME, Cash Productivity, Market leverage. These anomalies were picked as those with the highest combined rank where the ranks are based on the absolute value of the Spearman correlations in Panel B of Figure 5 and the R^2 from the spanning tests in Figure 7, Panel B. The sample period is 196306 to 202406.

Intercept	0.81 [2.85]	0.11 [4.70]	0.11 [4.82]	0.97 [4.12]	0.12 [5.21]	0.12 [5.01]	0.48 [1.77]
OAE	0.12 [0.21]	0.74 [1.69]	0.14 [2.94]	0.16 [3.43]	0.13 [2.68]	0.13 [2.74]	0.45 [0.88]
Anomaly 1	0.94 [5.93]						0.11 [7.45]
Anomaly 2		0.11 [2.96]					-0.48 [-1.34]
Anomaly 3			0.48 [3.26]				0.21 [2.42]
Anomaly 4				0.36 [5.64]			0.18 [1.58]
Anomaly 5					0.20 [1.97]		-0.45 [-0.58]
Anomaly 6						0.50 [2.88]	-0.19 [-1.99]
# months	732	732	727	727	727	727	727
$\bar{R}^2(\%)$	1	0	1	1	1	1	0

Table 5: Spanning tests controlling for most closely related anomalies

This table presents spanning tests results of regressing returns to the OAE trading strategy on trading strategies exploiting the six most closely related anomalies. The regressions take the following form: $r_t^{OAE} = \alpha + \sum_{k=1}^6 \beta_{X_k} r_t^{X_k} + \sum_{j=1}^6 \beta_{f_j} r_t^{f_j} + \epsilon_t$, where X_k indicates each of the six most-closely related anomalies and f_j indicates the six factors from the [Fama and French \(2015\)](#) five-factor model augmented with the [Carhart \(1997\)](#) momentum factor. The six most closely related anomalies, X , are gross profits / total assets, Operating leverage, Total assets to market, Book to market using December ME, Cash Productivity, Market leverage. These anomalies were picked as those with the highest combined rank where the ranks are based on the absolute value of the Spearman correlations in Panel B of Figure 5 and the R^2 from the spanning tests in Figure 7, Panel B. The sample period is 196306 to 202406.

Intercept	0.26 [2.72]	0.47 [4.19]	0.54 [4.54]	0.47 [4.15]	0.54 [4.55]	0.53 [4.48]	0.22 [2.41]
Anomaly 1	76.99 [19.54]						79.59 [15.94]
Anomaly 2		41.71 [9.26]					20.40 [4.55]
Anomaly 3			-2.16 [-0.43]				-13.24 [-0.90]
Anomaly 4				-54.43 [-7.48]			-25.49 [-3.99]
Anomaly 5					-13.77 [-2.35]		37.69 [6.93]
Anomaly 6						-6.48 [-1.33]	22.97 [1.60]
mkt	-13.08 [-5.71]	-11.48 [-4.29]	-11.74 [-4.03]	-11.25 [-4.12]	-13.42 [-4.66]	-11.14 [-3.83]	-10.15 [-4.29]
smb	2.58 [0.78]	-11.20 [-2.56]	8.10 [1.95]	26.07 [5.62]	8.66 [2.11]	8.57 [2.08]	-1.47 [-0.35]
hml	-24.00 [-5.06]	-35.03 [-6.15]	-53.88 [-6.74]	-0.49 [-0.05]	-46.21 [-6.64]	-49.05 [-6.33]	-24.31 [-2.88]
rmw	-17.94 [-3.58]	3.45 [0.60]	26.55 [4.78]	14.33 [2.57]	25.55 [4.63]	26.53 [4.81]	-33.67 [-6.27]
cma	10.05 [1.54]	-10.28 [-1.34]	-3.23 [-0.40]	0.41 [0.05]	-1.24 [-0.15]	-3.82 [-0.47]	4.79 [0.75]
umd	0.36 [0.16]	1.69 [0.63]	1.87 [0.60]	4.12 [1.52]	-0.59 [-0.19]	0.78 [0.25]	11.36 [4.31]
# months	732	732	728	728	728	728	728
$\bar{R}^2(\%)$	51	33	25	31	26	25	56

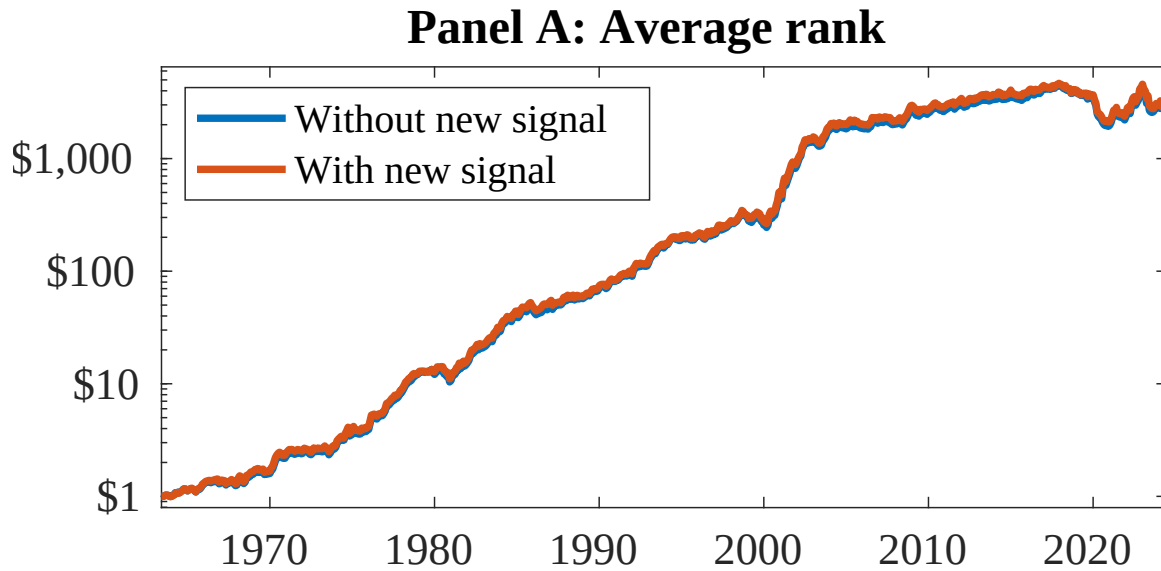


Figure 8: Combination strategy performance

This figure plots the growth of a \$1 invested in trading strategies that combine multiple anomalies following [Chen and Velikov \(2022\)](#). In all panels, the blue solid lines indicate combination trading strategies that utilize 154 anomalies. The red solid lines indicate combination trading strategies that utilize the 154 anomalies as well as OAE. Panel A shows results using "Average rank" as the combination method. See [Section 7](#) for details on the combination methods.

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